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SHORT-PAPER

Initial Reflections on GenAI-Based Game Remixing as an Explorative Practice

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Initial Reflections on GenAI-Based Game Remixing as an Explorative Practice

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Abstract

This paper explores the generative potential and structural limitations of GenAI-based game remixing as an experimental design practice. Through the creation and critical analysis of three hybrid games generated by large language models, we identify patterns of breakdown that render these remixed artefacts effectively unplayable. We introduce the concept of the *mis-mix* – a remix failure that reveals fundamental incompatibilities across game systems – and argue that GenAI's value lies less in the automation of design than in its production of speculative source material. Reframing GenAI as a partner in intuitive, human-led remix processes, we propose that its misfires and inconsistencies can be reappropriated as raw inputs in the emergence of playable media: game-like structures informed by both conscious and unconscious human interpretation.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing → Interaction design theory, concepts and paradigms**.

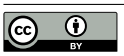
Keywords

AI, board game, game design, GenAI, methodology, narrative, play, practice, remixing

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1 Introduction

This paper explores how generative AI (GenAI) can be used to remix analog games in ways that expose the structural limits of both AI systems and game design logics. While remixing is a well-established cultural practice, its application in the context of *game rules* – especially across genres, formats, and mechanical paradigms – remains underexplored in academic and design research. This study investigates the potential of GenAI to function not as an autonomous game designer, but as a speculative partner in the creation of conceptual prototypes that provoke reflection and critical play.



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Our central research question is: What can GenAI-based remixing of analog games reveal about the constraints, misalignments, and latent assumptions of procedural creativity? By feeding prompts about canonical games into a large language model and critically examining the results, we seek to understand both *how* GenAI recombines systems and *where* it fails. These failures – contradictions, inconsistencies, and incoherent mechanics – are not merely shortcomings but opportunities for creative insight.

We introduce the concept of the *mis-mix* to describe a recurring failure mode in GenAI-generated games: a rule, mechanic, or structure that is ported from one game into another without systemic integration. Through close reading of three remixed artefacts (*Risk & Raise*, *Mansion of Secrets*, and *Trade War*), we show how GenAI tends to produce surface-level coherence while neglecting deeper functional logic. These "broken" games, we argue, are not failures to be discarded but fragments to be reappropriated – raw source material for emergent, human-centered remix processes.

This paper does not present an empirical evaluation or statistical analysis; rather, it offers a reflective, design-led investigation grounded in conceptual remix practice. While a participatory live event is planned for future implementation, the current focus is on analyzing the design artefacts themselves as speculative provocations. By reframing GenAI not as a solution engine but as an idea-generator, we suggest that its misfires and inconsistencies can catalyze new forms of *playable media* – experiential structures shaped through both machine output and intuitive human remix.

2 Theoretical Framing

The concept of remix in digital culture has been deeply examined by Eduardo Navas [8], who distinguishes between selective and regenerative remixes. The remixed games analyzed here exhibit both modes: selectively amplifying recognizable mechanics while attempting – but often failing – to generate fully new systems. Jenkins' [4] notion of *convergence culture* frames how remix bridges old and new media; in our case, GenAI bridges analog game structures with digital generation.

Lev Manovich's [7] idea of *deep remixability* is especially resonant: remix not just of content, but of form, method, and logic. GenAI technically fulfills this potential by recombining game elements, yet fails to deliver coherence, demonstrating its current inability to grasp games as systems rather than textual artifacts. Kultima's [5] *game design praxiology*, focused on creativity through constraints, helps contextualize the failures observed here not as dead ends but as design inputs. Our study thus builds on this lineage, positioning GenAI remixing as a speculative and diagnostic lens into the procedural imagination of game design.



Figure 1: AI-generated image of *Trade War*, a speculative game that remixes chess and *Monopoly*

3 Remix Experiments

We examined three GenAI-generated game remixes to understand how rule systems were recombined and where breakdowns occurred.

Risk & Raise combines the strategic conquest of *Risk* with the bluffing of *Poker*. The AI introduces a betting mini-game during combat, but the result is structurally incoherent. Resource systems (chips, troops) conflict; winning conditions contradict; and players are given too few materials. Mechanics are layered rather than integrated, revealing a surface-level recombination.

Mansion of Secrets merges *Cluedo* (or *Clue*[1]) with choose-your-own-adventure mechanics. While promising in concept, narrative choices do not meaningfully interact with clue collection. GenAI confuses metaphor with mechanic (e.g., "narrative paths" become literal movement), and character abilities reference story passages that may not exist. The result is a decorative, not procedural, remix.

Trade War, blending *Chess* and *Monopoly* (Figure 1), is the most ambitious. It introduces asymmetric powers, tariff systems, and a global stability track. Yet the rules lack specificity – particularly for how chess-like "policy pieces" function. Thematically rich but mechanically unplayable, it exemplifies GenAI's tendency to prioritize concept over operability.

4 Discussion

When reflecting on the observed qualities of the created artefacts, it should be noted that they are remixed from quite diverse medial texts. The concrete experiment mixes board games with a card game (remix 1), a niche narrative format (remix 2) and chess (remix 3). All of these remixes, specifically the second one, are arguably challenging tasks even for human game designers.

Still, ostensively, the GenAI succeeds, and creates three remixed versions. They might not be fully complete (the CYOAB-part in *MANSION OF SECRETS* is missing yet), but there are no immediately visible structural gaps or omissions. This impression of apparent completeness might be supported by the choice of source material which are classic and working game rules. The remixes can then simply additively combine them (as can be seen, for instance, in the *Poker* minigame phase in *Risk & Raise*). However, an inspection of the artefacts reveal them to be practically unplayable games, because the rules are inoperable. The question is, how are they inoperable, and what can one learn about AI-based game remixing as an explorative practice and also about GenAI, remixing and game design by analysing the (broken) artefacts?

Obviously, GenAI successfully re-arranges (game rule) texts in readable combinations. The remixes which are created in this experiment, exhibit local (partial) consistency, but also clearly lack global (systemic) consistency. The combination or interaction of the rules from various sections turns out to be unbalanced, incomplete or contradictory. This can be seen, for instance, in the rules for *MANSION OF SECRETS*, when both the 'CHARACTER ABILITIES' and the 'GAMEPLAY' sections appear to make sense, each by themselves, but when connecting them, the content falls apart (for example, Professor Plum can read extra story paragraphs that may not exist in the game materials). In the rules for *TRADE WAR*, the critical procedural details of how the chess-inspired policy pieces actually move or function, and how tariffs functionally impact gameplay are missing. The breakdowns in the remixed games highlight the critical importance of systemic coherence in game design. Games are systems, and they only work as a whole; a loose end in a (competitive) game deflates it like a balloon.

In the artefacts, the AI pretends or simulates results; that is, it claims ideal results or success, but, in fact, does not deliver. This can be clearly observed in the *MANSION OF SECRETS* rules, when the AI claims to have created a game that integrates game play with narrative, supports replayability and deeply strategic play; when, actually, the integration and the replay value are, at best, dubious, and the strategic depth is comparable to the unmixed game of *Cluedo*, that is, shallow.

Games need to work from the players' perspective. Games need balance, or they can play with balance. The remixed games in this study are quite unbalanced. In human-made designs, a specific balance is often achieved by intense playtesting, intuition, the designer's experience or accident, but the technical combination of rules in new configurations as observed in the experiments falls short. GenAI shows limited awareness of game balance considerations, creating mechanics that would clearly create unfair advantages (such as Mrs. Peacock's ability to peek at solution cards). The remixes are shallow mixes, in which established mechanics are mildly re-arranged in layers or phases, but not truly integrated with each other (such as, integrating the troops currency with the *Poker* currency in the *Risk* remix). This practice might be labled 'additive' rather than 'transformative' or 'combinatorical' remixing. The scrutinized remixes lack integration, in the sense that parts are added to each other, such as a poker minigame to a *Risk* game, or some CYOAB snippets to an otherwise mechanical mystery board game. But the parts are not unfolded within each other, to acquire and exhibit new qualities, characteristics or ways of expression. True integration requires reconceptualizing both source games to create a cohesive new system, a process that appears beyond current GenAI capabilities. The boundaries between the source artefacts remain clearly visible, and the created artefact remains a frankensteinian construction. GenAI tends to produce 'stitched together' designs where the seams between source materials remain evident. Such

[1]The game was originally created as *Murder!* by Anthony E. Pratt 'around 1944' [6]. It was published as *Cluedo* by Waddingtons, in the UK, in 1949. The simultanious North American release through Parker Brothers was titled *Clue* (ibid.). The game is still known as *Clue* in North America and as *Cluedo* elsewhere [3].

remix failures can highlight conceptual differences in the source materials. In the case at hand, the second remix experiment is unable to meaningfully integrate narractive with game play in any kind of satisfying form, and thus emphasizes it.

The experiments appear to confirm a number of informal expectations about GenAI. Bad math has been known as a hallmark of GenAI, and this can also been observed in the experiment (for instance, in the unsufficient numbers of player tokens and betting chips described in the *Risk* remix). Another typical GenAI fault appears to be the inability to distinguish between metaphorical or literal uses of language. In the game rules, the AI remix mistakenly suggests for the in-game characters to traverse the game board by 'following narrative paths'. This reads well, but, of course, narrative paths are not literally transporting in-game characters from one board location to another. There is a lot of slack introduced in GenAI-remixed game rules. Text repetitions, rule overlaps and meaningless playing options abound (such as, players asking other players about their (secret) discoveries, and moving players' tokens within rooms, both in *MANSION OF SECRETS*). GenAI incorporates features (such as tariffs and global trade) into *TRADE WAR* that only minimally benefit gameplay experience, but increase complexity and compromise playability.

This study introduces the concept of a *mis-mix* to describe elements that are transferred from one game to another without proper adaptation, creating conceptual or procedural contradictions. A mis-mix occurs when a feature from one source material is incorporated into a remix despite being conceptually or mechanically incompatible with the target context. This is observed in remix 2's transfer of a timing mechanic from a CYOAB to a board game, and in remix 3's chess piece movement rules, which clearly do not interface with the rest of each remix. The occurrance of mis-mixes in GenAI-created remixes suggests that effective remixing requires more than recognizing surface-level similarities; it demands deep understanding of how game systems function holistically.

5 Conclusion

This study set out to propose and demonstrate an explorative practice, that is, the GenAI-based remixing of different games, followed by the critical inspection of the created artefacts. This practice is intended to provide an investigative lense on the momentary and possibly invariant natures, characteristics and properties of GenAI, remixing and game design.

The inspection found multiple concrete issues in the remixed artefacts that render the created games effectively unplayable: The AI simulates ideal results, that is, it claims success, rather than actually delivering. The remixes contain glitchy rules. The remixes exhibit partial consistency, but lack systemic consistency. The remixes are relatively simple, additive compositions, in phases or layers. GenAI fails to distinguish between metaphorical and literal uses of language.

The study introduced the notion of *mis-mix* to describe elements transferred from one game to another without proper adaptation, creating conceptual or mechanical contradictions in the remix. This phenomenon highlights how successful remixing requires more than selective addition; it demands systemic and meaningful integration.

The breakdowns of GenAI-remixed game play emphasizes a number of aspects of successful game design; specifically, the requirement of umambiguous completeness and consistency on all levels and careful balancing (for instance, of abilities, features, positions, reward mechanisms).

The findings may point to a number of implications beyond the immediate experiment, for the practice of GenAI-based game remixing as an explorative lense. One can speculate that the expressive or experiential gamut is getting smaller by (GenAI) remixing, if the same game mechanics are mixed repeatedly. GenAI reproduces existing patterns to a large degree (or even exclusively), so it is unclear if more variety and divergence or more convergence is the main motif in the artefacts it produces.

The created artefacts may support ideation and serve as inspiration, for instance, when they exhibit unexpected juxtapositions of aspects that have usually not been combined, for creative exploration by human designers. The authors see games as vehicles of expression for players, so they expect that remixing folds and unfolds specific and undeterministic meanings only in interaction with players; and this process certainly is not closed or closing, but appropriative, so AI game remixing may offer novel (intended, arbitrary and accidental) forms and venues of expression for players.

The experiments suggest that while GenAI currently lacks the systemic coherence and design intuition required for fully functional game creation, its strength lies in generating provocative fragments—conceptual source material that can catalyze human creativity. Rather than treating GenAI as a designer, one might engage it as an idea-generator, a machine that externalizes latent patterns, juxtapositions, and metaphoric misfires. In this role, GenAI becomes a partner in speculative play, helping transform conscious and unconscious thought into emergent forms of *playable media* [1, 2].

This study collected initial reflections; there exist many angles which can be employed and investigated in the future. One such angle is the role of and integration of (human) game designers in GenAI-supported iterative co-creation collaborative remixing processes. Another angle is the identification of overlaps and differences of remixing within media (such as games or game genres) and of remixing across medial boundaries. Finally, an angle might be to interface the remixing of games with the practice of AI-automated game testing.

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